Brezhnev receiving a 21-gun salute before cruising past flag-waving crowds like a conquering hero in an open-topped limousine with whitewall tires. From a balcony on Alexanderplatz, a journalist saw the ailing Kremlin chief gripping the side of the car firmly ‘and only occasionally raised his free hand to wave’. To add to the festivities, East European leaders were joined by Asian and African representatives, including Joshua Nkomo and the PLO’s Arafat. The occasion of the 30th Anniversary was also used to ink an agreement between British editor Robert Maxwell and the SED to publish a Honecker ‘autobiography’ to be issued by Pergamon Press. When completed, it filled 300 pages of singlespaced typescript and, as the focus was more political than personal, Honecker only penned a few childhood sketches, the rest was ‘composed’ by fourteen Central Committee departments or, as one commentator put it, ‘party official first-person narrators’. Inevitably, the book, From My Life, was loaded with self-justification and perfectly captured his vision: Erich Honecker, revolutionary, peacemaker, statesman.

Around this time, Honecker was confronted with more immediate problems when Brezhnev embarked upon an invasion of Afghanistan aimed at bolstering the faltering communist regime in Kabul. In speech after speech, Honecker was publicly an unflinching supporter of the action, but privately believed it had no clear attainable objective, a view also articulated by Bishop Albrecht Schoenherr, chairman of the Evangelical Church Federation in East Germany, who said the invasion was ‘not viewed with enthusiasm’ by the GDR leadership. Speaking on Radio Free Berlin, Schoenherr added that while the GDR could not escape from the obligations of its alliance, ‘an aggravation of the situation is certainly not what East Germans would like to see’.16 Indeed, several protests took place across the GDR. In one, the words ‘Russians out of Afghanistan’ were daubed on walls in Rostock, while pamphlets were thrown from a moving car during the rush hour in front of Leipzig’s main railway station. On these it was written: ‘Now we know what we are arming for; the Russians need weapons and our support.’17

While the Soviets were absorbed in battle, international distaste at the aggression prompted President Carter to curtail the export of American grain to the USSR, postpone the ratification of the Salt II treaty, ban the sale